

Free credits, in order

Two sittings, about ninety minutes total, no money and no equity. The order is the only part that matters.

Countercite · 31 August 2026 · every figure marked [review], confirm on the page before relying on it

Why order, and not amount

AWS Activate credits can be spent on Claude models running on Amazon Bedrock. That is worth confirming because AWS Marketplace normally sits on the credit exclusion list, and Anthropic models bill through Marketplace. The Activate terms carve them back in by name.

The catch is that **you get one bite**. Every AWS offer requires you to be new to Activate. Two doors lead in, and they are not worth the same:

DOOR	REPORTED CREDIT	REQUIRES
AWS Activate Founders, applied for directly	\$1,000 [review]	A domain email. Nothing else.
Via the YC Startup School deals page	\$2,500 to \$5,000 [review, sources disagree]	Free enrolment. No equity, no application, no interview.

Walking through the first door may close the second. That is the entire reason this document exists. The larger figure is not confirmed, and it is free to find out.

WHAT THIS IS WORTH IN REAL TERMS

The whole day 1 to 30 accuracy-proving phase costs about \$120 of model spend at 300 cases. Even the smaller \$1,000 covers that several times over. The difference between the two doors is not survival, it is a year of not thinking about the bill.

① First sitting: YC Startup School, about 20 minutes

1. Go to startupschool.org.
2. Sign up. Use the email on your own domain, not a personal one.
3. Fill in the short company profile. A one-line description and a stage are enough. There is no review and no acceptance; enrolment is open to anyone.
4. Once inside, find the **Deals** section in the navigation.
5. Find the AWS offer. Read what it actually says: the credit amount, the expiry, and any condition about being new to Activate.
6. **Stop and write those three things down before clicking anything.**

THE ONE THING TO CHECK

If the AWS deal on that page is worth more than \$1,000, claim it there and skip the direct Founders form entirely. If it is worth \$1,000 or less, close the tab and use the direct form instead. Do not claim both; the second will be rejected and may burn the first.

While you are inside, look at what else the Deals page lists. Notion, Linear, HubSpot and Vercel all gate their best tier on partner affiliation, and Startup School by itself does not count as one. That is now confirmed rather than assumed, so do not spend time on those four. Anything else on the page is a bonus.

② Second sitting: AWS, about 30 minutes

Whichever door you chose, the AWS side works the same way.

1. Create an AWS account if you have none. New accounts get about **\$200** of credit with no application at all: roughly \$100 at signup and \$100 across five onboarding tasks, one of which is testing a prompt in Amazon Bedrock [review].
2. Apply for Activate through whichever door won, using the domain email address. Reports say `@gmail.com` is auto-rejected, and that the email domain must match the website domain, so the one-page site needs to be live first.
3. When credits arrive, open the **Billing** console, then **Credits**, then the credit itself.
4. Read the **Applicable Services** field.

THIS FIELD SETTLES EVERYTHING

If Bedrock or AWS Marketplace is not listed there, no wording in the Activate terms matters for that particular grant. One report describes credits covering several Claude models while a newer one was charged in cash in the same account. Check the field, then run one small Bedrock request and look at the next bill before assuming coverage.

Use

AMAZON BEDROCK

, not Claude Platform on AWS. They are different products. The credit carve-out names Bedrock, and the other one is reported to be priced in units that are never discounted.

What to skip, so no afternoon is wasted

PROGRAMME	WHY NOT
Notion, Linear, HubSpot, Vercel	All require partner affiliation. Startup School does not qualify. Confirmed.
GitHub for Startups	Requires an accelerator or investor relationship.
Stripe Atlas	\$500 now and roughly \$400 a year forever, against a sub-\$1,000 budget.
NVIDIA Inception	Hard-requires an incorporated entity.
PostHog (\$50,000)	Biggest number on any list and the least useful here. Analytics is already \$0 on the free tier, and the cost problem is inference. Apply if you have fifteen spare minutes, not before the AWS work.

Worth doing after AWS

Both are short and neither is urgent.

- ☐ **Cloudflare for Startups**, reported at \$5,000 on a bootstrapped tier reachable with a promo code and no investor. The site already runs on Cloudflare, so the credit lands where it is used.
- ☐ **Anthropic's startup programme**. Membership appears open to anyone; the credits appear to require institutional funding. Sources conflict. Ten minutes to find out.

The order, on one line each

- ☐ Buy the domain and get the mailbox working. Everything below needs it.
- ☐ Put a one-page site at that domain, because the email domain must match it.
- ☐ Enrol in YC Startup School and read the AWS deal.
- ☐ Claim AWS through whichever door is worth more. One door only.
- ☐ Open the credit in the Billing console and read Applicable Services.
- ☐ Run one small Bedrock request and check the next bill.
- ☐ Cloudflare, then Anthropic, then PostHog, when there is spare time.

Every figure here comes from a search summary rather than a page I could open, because the proxy blocks the vendor sites. Amounts and conditions change often. Treat the numbers as the reason to look, not as the answer, and read what is on the screen. Full evidence and the conflicting sources are in `research/08-CREDITS-VERIFIED.md`.